order to disguise its true purpose, however, the raft would be given a cover, and officially said to be carrying diplomatic presents for Ranjit Singh deemed too delicate to send by road.

Given the Maharajah's almost obsessive love of fine horses, Ellenborough agreed to the ruse of sending out from Suffolk a team of huge English dray horses, a breed never before seen in India. A heavy gilt English carriage was later added to the gifts, just in case Ranjit Singh ordered the carthorses to be sent by road. Later it was agreed to extend the expedition so that a British intelligence officer disguised 'in the character of a merchant' would pass on through Afghanistan to Bukhara, to assess the possibilities of 'introducing English manufactures into Central Asia'. This officer was of course to take covert notes and make maps as he went, to test the degree of Russian influence in the Central Asian oasis towns, and to report on the ease with which a troop of Cossacks might sweep past the Oxus into Afghanistan, and hence down into India.[59]

Ellenborough's first choice for an 'able and discreet officer' to lead the expedition had been William Fraser's brother, the artist, writer and spy James Baillie Fraser, who had travelled extensively in Persia a decade earlier, had made friends with the Shah and spoke perfect Persian.[60] But Fraser was busy at that moment trying to save his family estates in Inverness – he had got into debt building a massive extension of his house in order to have the Persian princes to stay. So Ellenborough settled instead on an unknown but ambitious twenty-five-year-old linguist and Pottinger protégé who had just won a prize for producing the first new map of the mouth of the Indus since Alexander Dalrymple's celebrated chart of 1783.

The name of this young officer was Alexander Burnes.

In the summer of 1830, five dapple-grey Suffolk carthorses arrived at the docks of Bombay after a voyage of six months; one of the original six, a mare, had died at sea. A fortnight later, after recovering their strength grazing on the green meadows of Malabar Hill, they were packed off again, this time towards the Indus estuary, accompanied by the large gilt carriage.

Waiting for permission to land, the ships were tossed about by gales, dismasting two of the boats and splitting the sails of a third, the one in which Burnes was sailing. The horses, now used to life on the waves, seem to have taken it in their ample stride; but the carriage was badly damaged by